

Monsoon woes: On the southwest monsoon and the northeast

Northeast States need a long-term plan to **deal with** floods

The southwest monsoon has made a **torrential** entry and, expectedly, has **wreaked considerable havoc**. While the monsoon's **advent** from Kerala, and its subsequent journey northwards, **is** a cause for celebration, **given** its association with the economy, this is only one branch of the monsoon — the Arabian Sea branch. A day or two after its **onset** over Kerala, and sometimes simultaneously, the Bay of Bengal branch of the monsoon makes its way from the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and enters the northeastern States first before bringing in rains to the eastern States. Frequently, however, this eastern onset is **accompanied** by destruction from floods and landslides. This year has been one such **instance**.

In Assam, 10 major rivers were flowing above their danger-level mark and in all, more than three lakh people across 19 districts of Assam have been affected in a wave of floods that has **disrupted** everyday lives. Tripura also **witnessed** heavy to very heavy rainfall across many districts over the weekend and is expected to receive an extremely heavy **downpour** for most of the week. The death **toll** in rain-induced landslides, floods, flash floods, and lightning across the northeastern region **was** 30 until May 29 and on a single day, May 31, 22 people had lost their lives according to official estimates. In North Sikkim, landslides have **marooned** about 1,500 tourists with **arterial** roads getting blocked from **incessant** rains. A bus **plunged** into the **swollen** Teesta river, killing at least two people, with the rest of the passengers missing. This is only June and history has it that with the monsoon expected to be 'above normal', **it would not be a stretch** to expect a **spate** of disasters. To be sure, the India Meteorological Department expects that the northeastern States will likely get less than their normal quota of rain, but the base level of monsoon rains in these States is higher than many States in India. This is a reason why extremely heavy rain and **associated** damage is a **hard-wired** feature of the monsoon in the northeastern States, even in a year of relative **scarcity**. The northeastern States also experience a smaller monsoon, between October to December, and thus it becomes all the more essential to craft a plan that **accounts for** the region's year-long **vulnerability**. Historically, infrastructure **development** in these States **has** not kept **pace** with the rest of the country. While challenging geographical conditions are a major reason for this, there needs to be a systematic review involving all the affected States and the Centre to **evaluate** a **sustainable** long-term plan to reduce **fatalities** and the **widespread** destruction annually. **[Practice Exercise]**

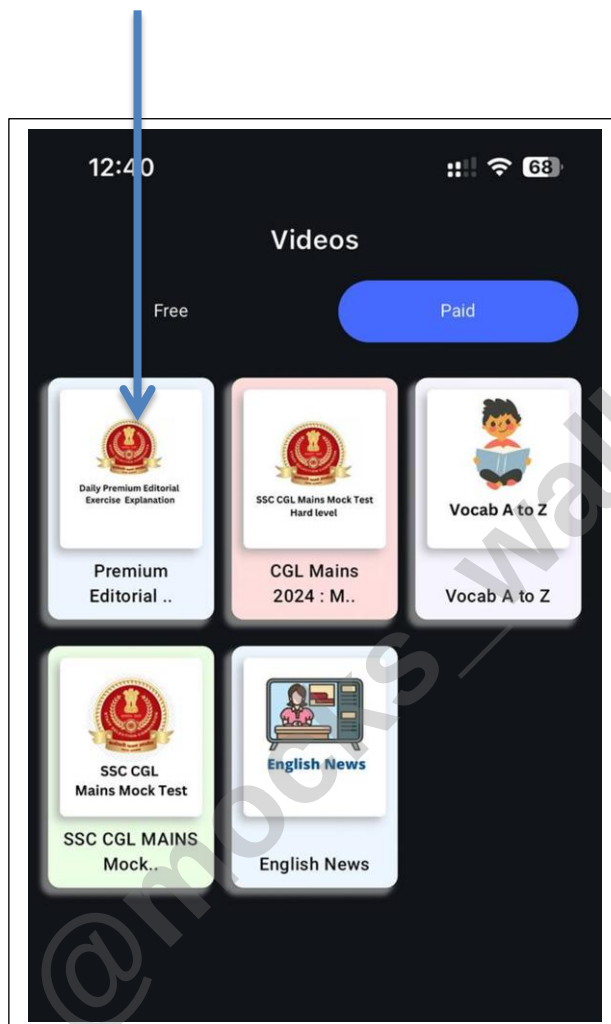
- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Woes** (noun) – troubles, problems, difficulties, miseries, hardships परेशानियाँ
2. **Deal with** (phrasal verb) – handle, manage, address, tackle, cope with निपटना
3. **Torrential** (adjective) – heavy, intense, violent, drenching, relentless मूसलाधार
4. **Wreak havoc** (phrase) – cause destruction, devastate, ruin, damage, unleash chaos भारी तबाही मचाना
5. **Considerable** (adjective) – significant, substantial, large, ample, notable उल्लेखनीय
6. **Advent** (noun) – arrival, coming, emergence, appearance, onset आगमन
7. **Given** (preposition) – considering, taking into account, in view of, due to, because of को देखते हुए
8. **Onset** (noun) – beginning, start, commencement, initiation, outbreak शुरुआत
9. **Accompany** (verb) – go with, occur with, be associated with, escort, coincide साथ होना
10. **Instance** (noun) – example, case, occurrence, situation, event घटना
11. **Disrupt** (verb) – interrupt, disturb, break, hinder, destabilize बाधित करना
12. **Witness** (verb) – see, observe, experience, undergo, record देखना
13. **Downpour** (noun) – heavy rain, deluge, rainfall, torrent, cloudburst तेज बारिश
14. **Toll** (noun) – number of deaths, casualties, loss, damage, cost मरने वालों की संख्या
15. **Maroon** (verb) – strand, trap, isolate, abandon, desert फँसा देना
16. **Arterial** (adjective) – main, principal, major, key, essential मुख्य (सड़क या मार्ग)
17. **Incessant** (adjective) – nonstop, continuous, unending, relentless, ceaseless लगातार
18. **Plunge** (verb) – fall, drop, dive, descend, tumble गिरना / डूबना
19. **Swollen** (adjective) – flooded, enlarged, bloated, expanded, overfilled उफनता हुआ
20. **It wouldn't be stretch** (noun) – something is very likely or reasonable
21. **Spate** (noun) – series, flood, wave, surge, succession बौछाड़
22. **Associated** (adjective) – related, connected, linked, correlated, involved संबंधित
23. **Hard-wired** (adjective) – inherent, built-in, ingrained, natural, intrinsic जन्मजात / स्वाभाविक

24. **Scarcity** (noun) – shortage, lack, deficiency, dearth, insufficiency कमी
25. **Account for** (phrasal verb) – explain, justify, consider, include, take into account जिम्मेदार होना
26. **Vulnerability** (noun) – weakness, exposure, risk, susceptibility, sensitivity संवेदनशीलता / जोखिम
27. **Pace** (noun) – speed, rate, tempo, rhythm, momentum गति
28. **Evaluate** (verb) – assess, judge, examine, estimate, appraise मूल्यांकन करना
29. **Sustainable** (adjective) – eco-friendly, viable, long-lasting, renewable, enduring टिकाऊ
30. **Fatality** (noun) – death, casualty, loss, demise, mortality मृत्यु
31. **Widespread** (adjective) – extensive, broad, prevalent, sweeping, far-reaching व्यापक

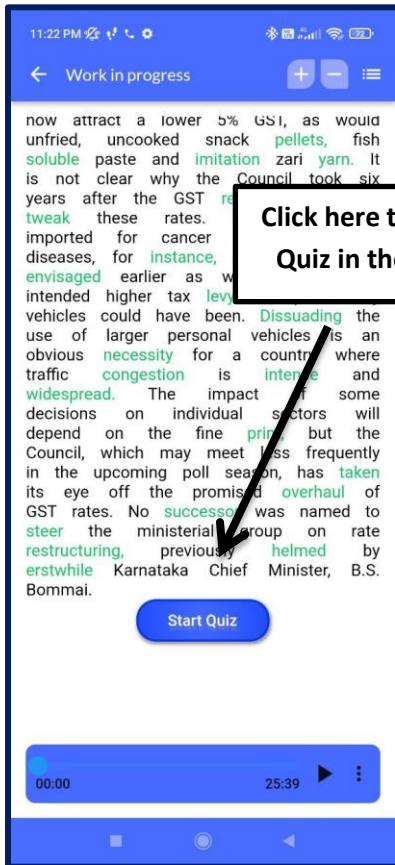
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



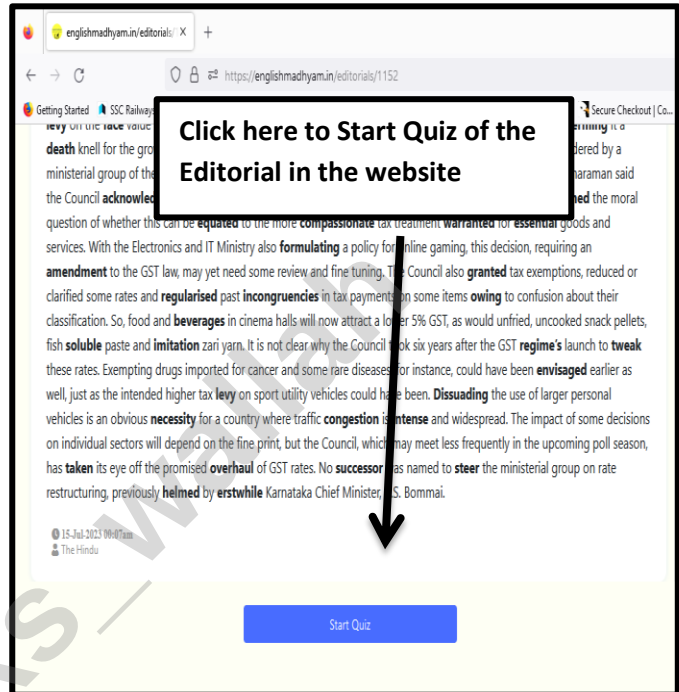
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Monsoon Arrival:** The southwest monsoon has begun with heavy rains, especially via the Arabian Sea and Bay of Bengal branches.
2. **Northeast's Early Impact:** The Bay of Bengal branch hits the northeastern States early, often causing floods and landslides.
3. **Current Flood Situation:** Assam is severely affected, with 10 major rivers above danger level and over 3 lakh people impacted across 19 districts.
4. **Tripura's Heavy Rainfall:** Tripura also experienced intense rainfall and is forecasted to face continued extreme downpours.
5. **Casualties:** As of May 29, rain-related events like floods, landslides, and lightning caused 30 deaths in the region; 22 more people died on May 31 alone.
6. **Sikkim's Crisis:** Landslides in North Sikkim have stranded 1,500 tourists and blocked crucial roads.
7. **Fatal Accident:** A bus fell into the swollen Teesta river, resulting in confirmed deaths and several passengers missing.
8. **Monsoon Season Just Begun:** These disasters are occurring at the very start of the monsoon, indicating the potential for worse ahead.
9. **'Above Normal' Monsoon:** Despite forecasts of slightly less rain than average in the Northeast, its higher rainfall base still leads to extreme impacts.
10. **Rainfall Intensity:** Even in relatively dry years, northeastern States experience high-intensity rains compared to most of India.
11. **Second Monsoon Phase:** These States also face a smaller monsoon period from October to December, adding to their flood vulnerability.
12. **Need for Long-Term Planning:** The region requires a comprehensive, year-round disaster preparedness and flood management strategy.
13. **Infrastructure Lag:** Northeastern infrastructure remains underdeveloped compared to other regions, worsening the monsoon's impact.
14. **Geographic Challenges:** Difficult terrain is a major factor in infrastructure delays, but cannot be the only explanation for lack of planning.
15. **Call for Coordination:** A coordinated approach between the Centre and State governments is essential for sustainable, long-term solutions to recurring monsoon disasters.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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